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NATION | P4

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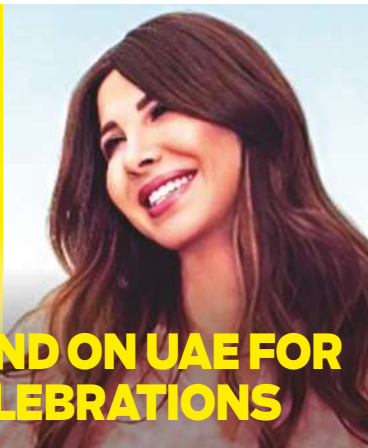


BUSINESS | P5

UAE's economy
expands by
3.6% in H1 2024

ENTERTAINMENT | P16

STARS DESCEND ON UAE FOR
NEW YEAR CELEBRATIONS



2025

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Ahmad Alotbi/Gulf News

UAE LIGHTS UP TO USHER IN THE NEW YEAR

The Corniche Street in Abu Dhabi is decked out in an array of lights as the city as well as the whole country get ready to welcome 2025. Each emirate has lined up a slew of activities, including stunning fireworks displays, to ensure residents and tourists have an unforgettable New Year's Eve experience. **SEE ALSO P2, P16**

Carter was a good friend of the UAE: Mohammad Bin Zayed

President pays rich tributes to former US leader's humanitarian services

DUBAI

BY SAJILA SASEENDRAN
Chief Reporter

President His Highness Sheikh Mohammad Bin Zayed Al Nahyan, yesterday expressed heartfelt condolences on the passing of former US President and Nobel Peace Prize laureate Jimmy Carter at the age of 100 on Sunday.

Referring to Carter as "a



■ Jimmy Carter

good friend of the UAE," Shaikh Mohammad shared a historic photograph of Carter with the Founding Father of the UAE, Shaikh Zayed Bin Sultan Al Nahyan.

"Together with the late

Shaikh Zayed, he laid the foundations for disease eradication efforts that continue to make a meaningful impact today," he added.

According to the UAE Embassy in the US, it was during their historic meeting in 1990 that Carter and Shaikh Zayed formed an alliance to eradicate Guinea-worm disease.

Earlier, the Carter Centre launched the Guinea Worm Eradication Programme to help countries with endemic dracunculiasis.

In 2001, Carter also became the first recipient of the Zayed International Prize for Environment.

SEE ALSO P4, P11

Visa violators face fines as UAE amnesty ends

Top official says many amnesty seekers were victims of fraudsters

DUBAI

BY ABDULLA RASHEED
Abu Dhabi Editor
AGHADDIR ALI
Senior Reporter

The UAE amnesty for residency violators has been hailed as a success, with 236,000 people in Dubai alone benefiting from the four-month grace period.

A top official yesterday also revealed that 55,200 exit permits were issued in Dubai, out of which 41,000 permit holders have left the UAE so far, with the remaining ones in the process of departing.

Today is the last day of the amnesty, with fines for over-

staying to be applied from tomorrow.

Lieutenant General Mohammad Al Marri, Director-General of the General Directorate of Residency and Foreigners Affairs in Dubai (GDRFA Dubai) thanked other government departments and private sector partners in facilitating amnesty seekers.

The applicants have regularised their residency by securing new jobs or opted to return to their home countries without fines or the imposition of a ban on re-entry to the UAE.

Many amnesty seekers were victims of fraudsters overseas who took money from them for UAE visas and falsely promised them jobs in the UAE, Lt Gen Al Marri said.

Several others had overstayed their visas due to financial problems, he added.

SEE ALSO P3

WORLD

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plane crash:
Grieving families
await remains of
loved ones | P10

BUSINESS

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airline Air Kerala
begins hiring
ahead of launch
in new year | P6

MIDDLE EAST

Red Cross
says war has
obliterated
health care in
north Gaza | P9



WORLD

India borewell
rescue: Race
against time to
save 3-year-old
girl | P11

Syria plans to hold elections in four years

SHARAA: KURDISH-LED FORCES TO BE INTEGRATED INTO NATIONAL ARMY

DUBAI

Syria's new leader Ahmad Al Sharaa in his first interview after toppling Bashar Al Assad said the country will hold elections but it could take four years.

Three weeks after he came to power, Sharaa, in a wide-ranging interview, also said local Kurdish-led forces which Turkey opposes should be integrated into the national army.

"The election process could take four years," Sharaa told Saudi-owned Al Arabiya.

"We need to rewrite the constitution" which could take "two or three years", said Sharaa.

He also noted the importance of ties with Iran and Russia, and called for the United States to lift sanctions.

United Nations Security Council Resolution 2254, adopted in 2015, outlined a roadmap for a political transition in Syria that included drafting a new constitution and holding UN-supervised elections.

Sharaa expressed hope that the incoming administration

of US President-elect Donald Trump would lift sanctions imposed under Assad on the now war-torn and impoverished country.

"The sanctions on Syria were issued based on the crimes that the regime committed," Sharaa said, adding that since Assad was gone, "these sanctions should be removed automatically".

Sharaa's Hayat Tahrir Al Sham (HTS) is proscribed as a terrorist organisation by many governments.

Sharaa said HTS's dissolution would be announced "during the national dialogue conference", without specifying a date, and emphasising that the dialogue would include all Syrians.

—AFP

SEE ALSO P9

● **Sharaa said HTS's dissolution would be announced 'during the national dialogue conference', emphasising that the dialogue would include all Syrians.**



SPORT

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his form is
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